



Google's first self-driving car, the Toyota Prius

it with a Lidar unit and other technology that he himself was working on, and succeeded in putting out a trial on public terrain.

The Prius, while not belonging to Google, can be hailed as the first indirect predecessor to Google's eventual self-driving efforts. The company brought Thrun, Levandowski and 13 other engineers together to form a team, and got a fleet of six Toyota Prius and one Audi TT as the test rig. Along with Lidar modules, each of these vehicles included cameras, imaging sensors, an onboard computer circuit and necessary signal processors and algorithms that would automate customised levers to operate acceleration, braking and steering – the three key functions. The initial goal was to drive 10 separate 100-kilometre stretches without accidents and interruptions, in full autonomous mode.

Needless to say, this got the ball rolling more than successfully, and laid the foundation for other technology and automobile companies to follow.

***Fun fact:** It is this experiment that opened a new job designation at Google, that of a driver with perfect driving records. The company, now an independent entity Waymo parented by Alphabet, continues to hire for this designation even today.*

On-road success, and Firefly

Beginning with the first Toyota Prius vehicles, Google's on-road self-driving experiments gradually turned into success. This was a gradual process, and